

the civilians and the limited civilian passenger and goods trains running at the time were under the supervision of the military high command. Railway staff involved in the war effort were accorded army ranks. Some traffic managers were given the rank of a brigadier, station superintendents were deemed second lieutenants, and other junior personnel were given ranks such as *subedar* major and havildar major – both senior JCO (junior commissioned officer) ranks in the British Indian Army.

Wartime rolling stock

As the war intensified, the railways became a site of battle with the Japanese attempting to destroy trains, their cargo, and the rail lines. To protect these assets, special armoured wagons were used on the lines. Mounted with machine guns and anti-aircraft cannons, these wagons chugged ahead of trains to eliminate threats from Japanese snipers or aircraft. Hospital trains were employed to transport wounded soldiers away from the battlefield. Refurbished passenger trains were fitted with a dispensary, storeroom, kitchen, and coaches for hospital staff, and could accommodate around 500 soldiers.

Transporting supplies

The railways were used to transport troops and war materials throughout India, although the vast majority were sent to the eastern frontier. Thousands of tonnes of supplies were sent every day by rail and water routes from Calcutta to Upper Assam. From here, the supplies were taken to China via a road through Burma to aid the Chinese Army in their efforts to contain the Japanese.

When Burma fell to the Japanese in May 1942, all possible land routes were cut off and Allied forces set up a perilous airlift, known as “The Hump” that flew from Assam to reach China over the Himalayas. Now in addition to other war supplies, large amounts of concrete had to be sent by rail for the construction of aircraft runways and other projects such as an alternate land route to China. Meanwhile, soldiers would travel as far as the train routes would take them to the edge of Assam before going the rest of the way to Burma on foot.